

his Facebook page; in dialogue with them about whatever they are thinking. This type of access was never possible before. Now you can be part of the conversation and debate.

I spent three years on Facebook. In 2007, I signed up to work for Barack Obama to direct online organising for his campaign. What we were interested in were votes because we knew that at the end of the day, we can have a lot of buzz but it doesn't convert into votes. We created 1,500 videos on YouTube but our supporters created tens of thousands of videos about who they were, why they were supporting the campaign, and what they believed their country could be.

Because people had a role and a voice, they felt that it was their responsibility to make sure Obama was elected. We raised over \$500 million online alone; average donations were less than \$100. We had 30 million people connected to our campaign online, that is one in five the number of people who came out and voted on election day. We crossed demographics and platforms in a way that was able to create a true watershed moment in American political history.

The question, then, is how can other people use this? What are the opportunities? I don't think it is smart to think about recreating that campaign any other time in America or in another cultural context, for instance, in India. There are very clear principles, however, that each of these initiatives demonstrates, which I would recommend for anyone, whether they are in politics, business, arts, you name it.

Individuals now have the capacity to share much more broadly than they ever had before. The opportunity that currently exists is to be able to get new anecdotal genuine feedback in real time on any idea.

The second implication is that even though it may seem that institutions are becoming less important, I would argue that they are becoming increasingly important. People ask me, what is the future of news and newspapers? I think there is a very robust future for these types of institutions. Today everybody has a megaphone; everybody is talking and there is so much more to listen to. We just can't simply listen to everything every day. Instead, we have to rely on institutions

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HUGHES (RIGHT) WITH SESSION CHAIRPERSON KALLI PURIE

and filters to tell us what is most important.

Lastly, the opportunities for collaboration have expanded. We used to live in a world where we had a pyramid. The most important people were those on the top who would just talk to a few individuals and make a decision where everyone else was affected. A more useful model is to think of our world as a network. It is much easier for individuals to talk to one another and solve problems collaboratively.

The only requirement for us is to think critically about how much technology integrates into our lives. We are so embroiled in our BlackBerrys, iPhones and laptops that we don't take time to think about how these objects and networks are changing the way we live. Facebook and other networks are not just there for your kids or for fun. They are serious institutions and platforms which are changing the way we live as individuals, the way we can participate in political and normative discussions; and the way we live our day-to-day lives. I am excited for the opportunities that these offer for collaboration in the future and I hope you are too.

For full speech and discussion, click to:
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DISCUSSION

Q. What are your views on controlling and policing Facebook to prevent use by sexual offenders?

A. Facebook gives complete control to users over their information. We have to be smart about who we talk to and what we talk about. The more we can teach ourselves, and more importantly to our kids, who are on Facebook and across the web, to be careful about the information that they share, the stronger we will be as a society.

Q. What do we expect in the next decade from Facebook?

A. Five to 10 years from now, most people won't need to come to Facebook with the same regularity that they do today. We need a place where we can find an answer to a very specific question like Google, but we also need filters that can help us make sure we can get the most interesting information as efficiently as possible.

Q. Will Facebook's 'corporate social responsibility' ever involve

"de-addiction" programmes for social networking sites?

A. We are social individuals and we crave for social interaction and we need that in order to exist as a society. I keep Facebook open all day but I don't think it's an addiction to Facebook. It's a way I use e-mail to find out what my colleagues, friends are saying or need to say or what they are saying to one another. So to that extent, social interaction is no addiction.

Q. How sustainable and

profitable are social media enterprises because it's a business and not a public utility service?

A. The future of advertising on a place like Facebook is much more about what we call social engagement advertisements. What is really promising to me is the world where advertising stops being about pushing things on people but becomes offering something and enabling people interested in it to say, "Oh! This is what I want to tell my friends."